

Transitioning Towards Sustainability: The Information Practices of Sustainable Food Consumers

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ABSTRACT

Sustainability is an emergent topic due to the increased climate and social issues caused by human activities. While sustainability is not a new concept in library and information science, its scope is often limited to library and information systems. This study aims to expand sustainability to human information behavior and practice. This poster reports initial findings from a pilot study in Jan – April 2022. Interviews and photo diaries with 6 sustainable food consumers about their information behaviors and practices were conducted and analyzed using the constructivist grounded theory methodology. We found that participants use sensory and embodied information in assessing the real impact of their sustainable food behaviors, and that this process is essential in the transition to sustainable food behaviors. Participants assess the impact of their transition to sustainable food by comparing information at different times, places, and between actors (individuals and food providers). This research sheds light on the role of time in everyday information use, and demonstrates that sustainability is a fruitful research area in human information behavior and practice.

KEYWORDS

Sustainability; Human Information Behavior; Food Consumption; Transition; Information Use

INTRODUCTION

Sustainability and sustainable development have drawn increased attention in various disciplines over the past few decades (Schoolman et al., 2012). Information will play an essential role in the transition toward a sustainable future (Kamińska et al., 2022). Sustainability research in library and information science (LIS) mainly focuses on reducing the energy consumption or carbon emissions in library and information systems, such as sustainable library buildings, collections, digital services, green Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) (Kamińska et al., 2022). However, sustainability in everyday life from the human-centered information behavior or information practice (IB/IP) perspective has been understudied. Therefore, this study expands sustainability research in LIS with a focus on everyday IB/IP.

In everyday life, household food consumption has a significant impact on health and the environment. Food is a nuanced field and has been an information-rich research area in LIS and IB/IP (e.g., Hartel, 2010; Ocepek, 2016, 2018). However, sustainable food consumers have not drawn much attention in the IB/IP field, perhaps in part because environmental and ethical concerns are not necessarily primary drivers in food choices. However, Polkinghorne (2021) recently described how moral concerns (e.g., animal welfare, environment) influence food-related information practices. Therefore, we aim to extend previous research on food-related everyday information practices by focusing on sustainable food consumers. The question we aim to address here is: *How do sustainable food consumers engage with information in everyday food-related consumption?*

METHOD

Constructivist grounded theory (Charmaz, 2014) was employed to explore the actions, processes, and meanings of sustainable food consumers' food choices and theorize their information practices. Constructivist grounded theory recognizes the active role of participants and researchers to co-construct knowledge in the process. Sustainable food consumers, in this study, refer to people who, in the last month, have made food choices based on environmental, political, social, or ethical concerns (Peattie, 2010; Schoolman, 2020).

Data were collected from pre-screening phone calls, photo diaries, and semi-structured interviews via email and video-conferencing tools (i.e., Zoom). Six participants, all sustainable food consumers who live in a large Northeastern state in the U.S., were recruited through special interest groups of sustainability from social media (e.g., Facebook) and snowball sampling between January and March of 2022. Participants are all women, white, and Democrats, which aligns with previous research on a typical demographic of sustainable consumers (Schoolman, 2020). Pre-screening phone calls ensured participants' eligibility and collected demographics and preferred pseudonyms. We also asked them to take photos of their sustainable food consumption behaviors (e.g., grocery shopping, vegetable gardens). These photo diaries were discussed during the interview. Semi-structured interviews focus on participants' (1) perception of sustainability, (2) food consumption and information practices based on photo-elicitation techniques (Clark-Ibáñez, 2004; Harper, 2002), (3) information behaviors/practices based on critical incident techniques (Flanagan, 1954; Sonnenwald et al., 2001). Notes were taken during the pre-screening phone calls. Interviews were audio-recorded and lasted from 45 to 90 minutes. In total, 46 photos and 381 minutes of recording were collected. Participants were compensated with a \$15 gift card after each interview. The recorded

interviews were transcribed verbatim, and photos were imported for data analysis. We used theoretical sampling to collect data and constant comparing, line-by-line coding, asking questions, and saturation to analyze data (Charmaz, 2014; Corbin & Strauss, 2014). Extensive jotting, analytical memoing, and weekly peer debriefings were also employed to increase the credibility of the findings (Charmaz, 2014; Corbin & Strauss, 2014; Miles et al., 2018).

FINDING: INFORMATION USE OF SUSTAINABLE FOOD CONSUMERS

The primary findings are centered around the use of information to guide sustainable food consumption. This section only reports on a relatively well-saturated concept in the analysis thus far: *assessing the real impact of individuals' sustainability transitions*.

Assessing the Real Impact of Individuals' Sustainability Transitions

Sustainable food consumption is not one single behavior in a linear process but involves various types of sustainable food shopping or acquisitions at different transitions simultaneously. Sustainability transitions include maintaining current sustainable food behaviors, adopting new ones, replacing one with another, or giving one up. For instance, Ann was not only buying food from local farms and growing vegetable gardens (maintaining a sustainable food behavior) but also paying more attention to labor rights (adopting a new sustainable food behavior).

During sustainability transitions, participants used information to assess the real impacts of their efforts. The process involves comparing sensory and embodied information about the impact of sustainable food practices at different times, spaces, or between individuals and food providers. First, participants compared visual information in different time. Valva had noticed more options of sustainably sourced foods in the restaurants since she started her sustainable food journey 17 years ago: *"there's been more things on menus, there's been more options in restaurants."* Similarly, after planting more native plants, Aama saw an increased number of pollinators and insects in her garden: *"I can see when more if I plant milkweed that the monarch butterflies are going to come, so if you know that I'm doing something that is impact that I can see more caterpillars."*

Second, participants compared embodied information at different times and spaces. Aama noted her bodily feeling of the hot temperature lasted longer in summer but praised the lower temperature under the tree in her backyard: *"I know in my backyard sitting under the trees how climatically different it, it feels."* Accordingly, the observed positive changes over time made participants optimistic about their real impact, which, in turn, encourages them to maintain sustainable food behaviors. As Valva noted: *"I feel like the more I move forward on that, the more companies will rise to that occasion."*

However, one participant also gave up current sustainable behaviors when comparing their own sustainable practices to companies' behaviors in a short period of time. During the COVID-19 pandemic, Louise recalled her negative feeling by observing the wasteful food packaging used by a restaurant while picking up food with her own reusable containers: *"It was sad because I would be there with my bag and my reusable container... I stand there and wait for them to fill the containers with food and see the amount [of plastic packaging] that's being sent out in just that short time that I'm standing there."* Therefore, participant perceived limited impact due to the observed unsustainable behaviors of food providers and discontinued their sustainability transition.

DISCUSSION

While there is no consensus on the definition of information use (Savolainen, 2008; Spink & Cole, 2006; Todd, 1999), researchers advocate the need to study how people use information to transform their everyday behaviors (Fidel, 2012; Spink & Cole, 2006). Our research supports this with empirical data. In addition, prior studies have shown how sensory and bodily experience informed daily food activities, such as grocery shopping (Ocepek, 2018), cooking, and eating (Polkinghorne, 2021). Our study further demonstrates how participants use embodied information to reinforce or discontinue sustainable food transitions. Our finding also illustrates that *time* impacts information use, because participants were informed by comparing changes of sensory (e.g., numbers of pollinators) and embodied information (e.g., temperature) before and after their sustainable behaviors. It echoes Dervin's Sense-Making (Dervin, 1999) that conceptualizes a human living in a time-space. Lastly, food providers could present more sensory and embodied information (e.g., visualizing sustainable changes over time) to encourage sustainability transitions.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

First, participants lack gender, racial, geographical, and political diversity. Second, we have a small sample size ($n=6$) in this pilot study. Research is ongoing and the theoretical sampling process will continue until we reach saturation (Charmaz, 2014; Corbin & Strauss, 2014; Low, 2019). Third, participants in our study went beyond sustainable food consumption by engaging in other aspects of their life (e.g., fashion, waste disposal). Therefore, our study shows a fruitful result of studying the nuanced and multifaceted concept of sustainability in the IB/IP field

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